

Psalms 14

The Fool's Denial and God's Refuge

The fool hath said in his heart, There is no God
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *The fool hath said in his heart, There is no God. They are corrupt, they have done abominable works, there is none that doeth good.*
- 2 *The LORD looked down from heaven upon the children of men, to see if there were any that did understand, and seek God.*
- 3 *They are all gone aside, they are all together become filthy: there is none that doeth good, no, not one.*
- 4 *Have all the workers of iniquity no knowledge? who eat up my people as they eat bread, and call not upon the LORD.*
- 5 *There were they in great fear: for God is in the generation of the righteous.*
- 6 *Ye have shamed the counsel of the poor, because the LORD is his refuge.*
- 7 *Oh that the salvation of Israel were come out of Zion! when the LORD bringeth back the captivity of his people, Jacob shall rejoice, and Israel shall be glad.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 14 diagnoses practical atheism—not mere intellectual doubt but a heart-level dismissal of God that produces corruption and oppression of the poor. Nearly identical to Psalm 53, it moves from a universal indictment (“there is none righteous, no, not one,” quoted by Paul in Romans 3) to comfort for the afflicted whose refuge is the Lord, and closes with longing for restoration. Henry reads it as exposing the moral root of society’s ills in denial of God rather than merely in bad behavior.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

The fool’s heart-creed—“there is no God”—leads to corrupt, abominable works. God looks down from heaven to see if any understand and seek Him; the verdict is universal: all have gone astray, none does good.

Verse 4-6

The wicked “eat up” God’s people like bread and never call on the Lord themselves, yet they will be filled with fear, for God is with the generation of the righteous. Their scorn for the poor man’s counsel is met by the fact that the Lord is his refuge.

Verse 7

A closing longing for salvation to come out of Zion, for God to bring back the captivity of His people—joy and gladness are the hoped-for result of that future restoration.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Denying God in the heart, not just the mind, is the root of corruption and oppression; yet God stands with the afflicted as their refuge and the psalm ends looking forward to full salvation and restoration.

Application for life today.

Notice practical, everyday atheism in yourself—moments when God is simply absent from your plans and desires, even if you would never say “there is no God” out loud. Let Romans 3’s use of this psalm humble any sense of moral superiority; all alike need grace. And if you are among the “poor” whose counsel is shamed by others, remember that the Lord Himself is your refuge.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where does practical atheism—living as if God is not really factored into decisions—show up in your life?

2. How does the universal indictment of verses 1–3 shape the way you view others’ failures compared to your own?

3. What would it look like to actively make the Lord your refuge this week rather than just agreeing with the idea?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).